

GROUNDING: Lalu built a helipad and sports complex on what was once the Jehanabad airport



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NITISH KUMAR, CHIEF MINISTER

to create a “Silk Route” to connect Bhagalpur (famous for silk) with Varanasi and Delhi.

Chief Minister Nitish Kumar feels many airports died an unnatural death due to sheer neglect. Samastipur is just one of them. Surrounded by a number of buildings, the airport has a 3,000-foot runway and was built in 1983. Since then, the airfield is mostly used during elections, when politicians descend from the skies in their choppers. According to Building Construction Department's Assistant Engineer R.P. Singh, the runway has been reduced to a couple of helipads. This is in contrast to the one at Chhapra, which has a 3,000-ft long metalled runway. Not surprising since the MP who represents the constituency is Railways Minister Lalu Prasad Yadav. But like most other airfields in the state, it springs to life only on the odd vvp visit or during elections.

During the decade-and-half long Lalu-Rabri regime, some of the airports used to witness sporadic take-offs and landings, thanks to their propensity to hop on to state government planes and helicopters on “social justice” tours. Two helicopters (Lalu called them *Uran-khatola*, meaning flying cots) belonging to Pawan Hans were kept on 24x7 duty for Lalu. The



state Government has three small airplanes, two of them beechcrafts. One was purchased when the state saw a fairly long spell of Governor's rule. Only when a popular government came to power did the state realise the enormity of the scandal involved in the plane's purchase. The comptroller and auditor general in his report pointed out: “The Government failed to realise value for money as it purchased a phased-out model of aircraft at the cost of Rs 13.23 crore without inviting competitive bids when a substantially up-

graded model of the same was available at a marginally higher cost”.

The Nitish Kumar Government, however, chose to ignore the report. Besides, by the standards of scams in Bihar, Rs 13.23 crore seemed like a pittance. As politicians cutting across party lines grouped together to push the scandal under the carpet, the state Government has vowed to develop neglected airfields in the belief that this will turn around Bihar's commercial and development fortunes. Welcome Aboard. ■